

NYC 311: What City Operations Should Do Next

Executive summary | 2022-01-01 to 2025-01-01 | 9,848,541 service requests analyzed

The question

Agency leaders need to know where complaint volume is concentrating, which backlogs are growing, and whether resolution time is fair across boroughs and income levels - without comparing agencies on the wrong baseline.

By the numbers

9.8M+	79%	7.8 hrs	3%
complaints (2022-2025)	of volume in top 5 categories	citywide median close time	open backlog growth YoY

Volume is concentrated. 79% of complaints fall in five families: Parking Enforcement, Noise And Sound, Housing Maintenance, Sanitation Cleanliness, Street And Sidewalk Infrastructure. Parking and noise alone account for nearly half of all volume.

Three decisions for next quarter

1. Clear the homelessness outreach backlog

Homelessness And Outreach carries the highest open-case pressure in the portfolio (33% of recent volume still open). Residents see this as visible failure even when median close times look fast. **Action:** surge outreach closure capacity and weekly backlog stand-ups.

2. Absorb the public-health complaint surge

Public Health volume rose +30% year over year (Critical priority); Consumer And Vendor Regulation also grew +31%, adding cross-agency inspection load. Rising volume plus longer medians signals closure-capacity strain. **Action:** align DOHMH field staffing to top growth ZIPs; treat DOHMH closure timestamps cautiously in SLA scorecards.

3. Close the parks equity gap - and fix how we measure it

Parks And Recreation shows the largest income-quartile resolution gap (+166% longer in lowest vs highest income ZIPs). Queens borough-wide medians are also worsening (+37%). **Action:** target parks maintenance in Q1 ZIPs; audit sparse quartile cells before using heatmaps in oversight settings.

Read this before you act

Fair agency comparisons require workload normalization - the same complaint type can span NYPD, DOT, and specialty agencies with different portfolios. **Geographic maps understate need** where residents file fewer complaints despite higher objective service gaps. **98% closure rate** does not mean 98% satisfaction; long-tail categories (trees, transit, housing violations) drive perceived delay.

Interactive dashboard: tuahung248.github.io/NYC311 | Extract snapshot: 2026-05-09 | Full pipeline and caveats in repository README and codebook.